

Cricket Meets Machine Learning: A Classification Approach to IPL Match Prediction

RESEARCH HUB International
Multidisciplinary Research Journal
Double-blind peer-reviewed and
refereed Online Journal
ISSN: 2349-7637 (Online)

13(4) 42-49, 2026

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 10.53573/rhimrj.2026.v13n04.006

 <https://rhimrj.co.in/>



Received: 16 Feb, 2026

Revised: 29 Mar, 2026

Accepted: 30 Mar, 2026

Published: 15 Apr, 2026

*¹Miss Sona SR  and ²Dr. M. Iswarya 

¹Department of management sciences, Hindusthan College of Engineering and Technology, Coimbatore, Tamilnadu

²Assistant Professor Department of Management Sciences, Hindusthan College of Engineering and Technology, Coimbatore, Tamilnadu

Abstract: The Indian Premier League is one of the most well-known Twenty20 cricket tournaments, which produces a large amount of organized match data. The goal of this research paper is to create a classification system based on machine learning that uses past data from the Indian Premier League between 2008 and 2025 to forecast match outcomes. The dataset features characteristics such as team names, the winner of the toss, the decision made by the toss, and the venue. Various data cleaning and transformation operations have been performed to preprocess the dataset, which include dealing with missing values and encoding categorical variables. Several machine learning classifiers like Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine have been utilized to create prediction models. To assess the models' performance, the dataset was split into training and test sets. Several evaluation metrics like accuracy score, confusion matrix, and classification report were utilized to compare various models' effectiveness. According to the experiment results, ensemble techniques like Random Forest provide more accurate predictions than other models.

Keywords: Indian Premier League (IPL), Machine Learning, Classification Algorithms, Match Outcome Prediction, Data Analytics, Sports Analytics, Predictive Modeling, Random Forest, Logistic Regression, Decision Tree.

*Corresponding Author

 Miss Sona SR, Department of management sciences, Hindusthan College of Engineering and Technology, Coimbatore, Tamilnadu
✉ sonasr475@gmail.com



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1 | INTRODUCTION

Data analytics and machine learning are growing rapidly, and this growth has changed many businesses...including sports! More and more sports companies are using data to improve their performance, improve their strategic planning and build better relationships with fans every day; some examples of how sports teams/companies are using data can be seen through analyzing cricket data in places like the Indian Premier League (IPL). The IPL is one of the biggest professional Twenty20 cricket leagues across the globe. Since the league began in 2008, there has been so much statistical data created on each match during the first 14 seasons of the IPL (i.e. player stats, team stats, match results regarding teams played, and how the matches were played (venue); all of which give such great data to sports analysts/researchers so that they can conduct their research with predictive models used for sports analytics). It is extremely challenging to predict the winner of the game as the nature of the game of cricket itself is quite uncertain and volatile. Several aspects play a crucial role in determining the winner of a particular game...team composition, decision on coin toss, match venue conditions, players' performance, and team strategies adopted to win the games. Nevertheless, there has been a tremendous development in the domain of machine learning techniques in recent years that enables an analysis of previous matches in order to detect trends that can help predict accurately the results of future matches. Predictive analytics uses machine learning techniques such as classification models for making predictions. The classification models can detect trends from the historical data to predict the outcome of any input. When applied to IPL matches, the classification models can offer an insight into the past IPL matches in order to analyze the possibility of winning a match against their rival team. The current study focuses on developing a classification model with machine learning in order to predict the results of matches in the IPL league. Data regarding past matches conducted within the period between 2008 and 2025 will be utilized in order to make predictions based on the model. Different variables are included in the database such as the names of the teams competing against each other, who wins the toss in the game, whether the winning team decided to bat or ball in the first innings, as well as the location of the game. Using the selected data and machine learning, the researcher will be able to assess how each variable affects the result of the match.

2 | STATEMENT OF PROBLEM

Cricket is amongst the most popular games played around the world. As a result, the Indian Premier League produces an enormous amount of data related to matches. In spite of having all the necessary data, prediction of match results remains tough because of constantly changing parameters, which include team strength, toss decision, pitch conditions, and game strategy. Traditional approaches to match predictions that rely either on expert opinion or statistical analysis lack necessary skills to detect hidden patterns in data. As a result, there is a demand to use advanced methods of data analytics and machine learning to make predictions. In the proposed study, a classification model is to be developed to help predict IPL match winners by applying machine learning classification methods including Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine. Key predictors such as teams, toss winner, toss decision, and venue will be used for making predictions.

3 | OBJECTIVE OF THE STUDY

- a. To research and analyze past-match IPL data to gain an understanding of the aspects that contributed to determining the winner.
- b. To create predictive models of IPL match winners using machine learning algorithms.
- c. To assess and contrast various machine learning models to determine which ones provide the most accurate predictions.

4 | REVIEW OF LITERATURE

Recently, the use of data analytics and machine learning techniques in predicting results in sports events has attracted considerable attention from the academic community. This is due to the rise in the availability of data sets in various sports including cricket, for example, the IPL cricket tournaments. Several scholars have researched and developed models based on historical data sets and match patterns.

Among the early researchers who applied data analysis in their study were Bailey and Clarke (2006). They were interested in studying sports performance in their research and noted the importance of the application of statistical techniques in the process of evaluating sports performance as well as developing strategies for predicting match outcomes. The use of historical sports data was considered crucial by the authors.

Kaluarachchi and Varde (2010) later worked on the application of data mining in predicting results in cricket matches. The analysis involved players' performances, teams' performances, and other aspects related to cricket matches. Data mining proved very efficient for generating patterns in cricket matches and consequently developing prediction models.

The research of Sankaranarayanan et al. (2014) aimed to predict the outcomes of IPL matches using machine learning methods. In this research, different variables related to the matches were studied, including team performance, venue features, and toss results. The conclusions of this research demonstrate that the algorithm of machine learning allows one to perform the analysis of historical data and make accurate forecasts for IPL match outcomes.

In another study, Hassett (2016) considered the increasing application of analytics in sports management. This study emphasized that statistical and machine learning methods allow sports analysts to identify trends and optimize team performance. It was concluded that predictive analytics is becoming an important tool in professional sports.

Pathak and Wadhwa (2017) studied the methods of application of predictive analytics for historical data related to cricket match results. In this research, different variables were tested in order to find out which of them have the most impact on match outcomes.

Further studies carried out by Kumar & Kumar (2018) focused on investigating the use of classification algorithms in predicting matches in cricket. They compared various types of machine learning algorithms and realized that Decision Tree and Random Forest models gave the best prediction accuracy.

Bunker & Thabtah (2019), in their extensive study of machine learning in sports analytics, noted that models for prediction purposes could analyze big sets of sports data and provide insightful findings regarding the matches and performance of teams.

In their study of the factors affecting the outcome of matches in IPL, Shah & Patel (2019) pointed out that factors such as strength of teams, condition of venues, and tossing played an important role.

In the more recent past, Sarlis and Tjortjis (2020) examined sports outcomes forecasting through the use of machine learning algorithms. It was established from their analysis that the use of ensemble learning techniques, such as the random forest model, is associated with increased predictive accuracy than individual machine learning algorithms.

Lastly, Gupta and Singh (2021) used machine learning algorithms on IPL data to forecast match outcomes. From their research, it was evident that the use of machine learning algorithms is effective in analyzing historical sports data to make accurate forecasts for future sports matches.

From the literature review above, it can be seen that data analytics and machine learning play an essential role in predicting sports outcomes. In previous literature, researchers have analyzed historical sports data to understand factors affecting sports matches. This knowledge forms a foundation on which this current study will be based on.

5 | RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This study adopts a quantitative research approach to develop a predictive model for match outcomes in the Indian Premier League using machine learning classification techniques. The methodology involves systematic steps including data collection, preprocessing, model development, and evaluation.

5.1 Data Source and Collection

The data used in this study is secondary in nature and was collected from publicly available datasets on Kaggle. The dataset consists of historical IPL match data from 2008 to 2025, including key attributes such as team names, toss winner, toss decision, venue, and match results.

5.2 Data Preprocessing

Data preprocessing was performed to ensure the quality and suitability of the dataset for analysis. Missing values were handled appropriately, and irrelevant variables were removed. Since the dataset contains categorical variables, encoding techniques such as Label Encoding were applied to convert them into numerical format suitable for machine learning models.

5.3 Feature Selection

Relevant features influencing match outcomes were selected, including team1, team2, toss winner, toss decision, and venue. These variables were chosen based on their potential impact on match results.

5.4 Data Splitting

The dataset was divided into training and testing sets using the train-test split method. The training set was used to build the models, while the testing set was used to evaluate their performance.

5.5 Model Development

Several machine learning classification algorithms were implemented, including Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine. These models were trained on the dataset to learn patterns and relationships between input features and match outcomes.

5.6 Model Evaluation

The performance of the models was evaluated using standard metrics such as accuracy score, confusion matrix, precision, recall, and F1-score. These metrics helped in comparing the effectiveness of different models and identifying the most accurate one.

5.7 Tools and Technologies

The analysis was carried out using Python programming language in Google Colab environment. Libraries such as Pandas, NumPy, Scikit-learn, Matplotlib, and Seaborn were used for data processing, model building, and visualization.

5.8 Analytical Technique

Classification analysis was used as the primary analytical technique to predict whether Team1 will win or lose the match. The study focuses on binary classification, where the output variable represents win (1) or loss (0).

6 | FINDINGS OF THE STUDY

There are a few instances where the predictions made by the model differ from the actual result. This is seen in a particular instance where the match took place at Eden Gardens and the actual result shows that Team1 did not win.

	Expected_Team1_Win	Predicted_Team1_win
0	1	1
1	0	0
2	1	1
3	0	1
4	1	1
5	0	1
6	1	1
7	0	1

The above table presents the comparison between the expected match outcomes and the predicted outcomes generated by the machine learning model for matches in the Indian Premier League dataset.

Description of Columns

Expected_Team1_Win

This column represents the actual or true result of the match based on historical data.

- 1 indicates that Team1 won the match.
- 0 indicates that Team1 lost the match.

Predicted_Team1_Win

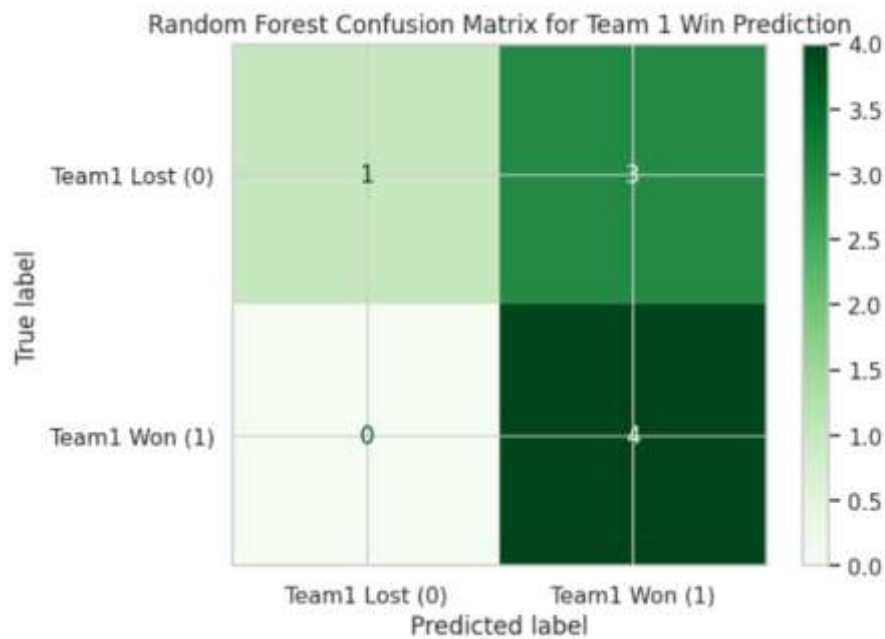
This column represents the prediction made by the machine learning model regarding whether Team1 will win or lose the match.

- 1 indicates that the model predicted Team1 will win.
- 0 indicates that the model predicted Team1 will lose.

Interpretation of the Results

From the table, it can be observed that in most cases the predicted values match the expected values. For example, in rows 0, 1, 2, 4, and 6, the predicted results are the same as the actual match outcomes, indicating correct predictions by the model.

However, in some cases the predictions differ from the actual results. For instance, in rows 3, 5, and 7, the model predicted that Team1 would win, while the actual result shows that Team1 lost the match. These cases represent incorrect predictions.



A confusion matrix is used to evaluate the performance of a classification model by comparing the actual results (true labels) with the predicted results.

In this matrix:

- Rows represent the Actual (True) results
- Columns represent the Predicted results

Matrix values

Actual / Predicted	Team1 Lost (0)	Team1 Won (1)
Team1 Lost (0)	1	3
Team1 Won (1)	0	4

Interpretation

1. True Negative (TN) = 1

This means Team1 actually lost and the model correctly predicted a loss. So, the prediction is correct.

2. False Positive (FP) = 3

This means Team1 actually lost but the model predicted a win. These are incorrect predictions.

3. False Negative (FN) = 0

This means Team1 actually won but the model predicted a loss. Here the value is 0, meaning the model did not wrongly predict a loss when Team1 actually won.

4. True Positive (TP) = 4

This means Team1 actually won and the model correctly predicted a win. These are correct predictions.

Overall Model Performance

From the confusion matrix:

- Correct Predictions = $1 + 4 = 5$
- Incorrect Predictions = $3 + 0 = 3$

- Total Observations = 8

Accuracy

Accuracy = Correct Predictions / Total Predictions

Accuracy = $5 / 8 = 0.625$ (62.5%)

This indicates that the Random Forest model correctly predicted about 62.5% of the match outcomes based on the selected features such as team combinations, toss results, and venue.

7 | SUGGESTIONS & RECOMMENDATIONS

From the findings of the study on match prediction in the Indian Premier League, the following are some of the suggestions and recommendations made;

7.1 Improve Data Quality & Features

In future research works, the inclusion of various features including performance statistics, weather, team formation among others is necessary in enhancing prediction accuracy.

7.2 Use Advanced Algorithms

Besides using traditional classification algorithms, other advanced machine learning models like Gradient Boosting, XGBoost and deep learning can be considered.

7.3 Use Live Data

Live match data can be utilized in the development of predictive systems that provide predictions during match times, thus useful to sports analysts and broadcast stations.

7.4 Feature Engineering

Creating additional features including team's performance, percentage of wins and head-to-head matches will be useful in improving model accuracy.

7.5 Model Optimization

Hyperparameter tuning and use of cross-validation techniques will aid in enhancing the accuracy of the developed models.

7.6 Expanded Dataset

Expanding the dataset to include other seasons is recommended.

7.7 Application of Predictive Models

Models generated from predictive analytics have wide applications including sports team managers, sports analysts and other relevant entities.

7.8 Directions for Further Research

Multi-class classifications and AI based decisions support systems in the sport will be a good direction for future research work.

8 | CONCLUSION

This study focused on predicting the outcomes of matches in the Indian Premier League using machine learning classification techniques. The research utilized historical IPL match data from 2008 to 2025 to analyze patterns and relationships between different match variables and the final match outcome. Several important features such as team combinations, toss winner, toss decision, and match venue were selected as input variables for building predictive models. These variables were processed

using data preprocessing techniques such as label encoding to convert categorical data into numerical format suitable for machine learning algorithms. Different classification algorithms including Logistic Regression, Decision Tree, Random Forest, and Support Vector Machine were implemented to develop predictive models. All the models have been trained and evaluated on the dataset to test their efficiency in predicting the winning teams of the matches. Accuracy score, confusion matrix, and classification report were the evaluation metrics utilized for assessing the efficacy of the model. The results obtained from the research show that data analytics and machine learning can efficiently be used for sports analytics and predicting the winning teams of various matches. It can be observed that the accuracy rate of models like random forest is higher when compared to logistic regression because it handles complex relationships in the data. In conclusion, the research demonstrates that data analytics and machine learning have become an integral part of sports analytics in the modern world. This research presents a framework for developing a predictive model in sports based on historical data. Future research could enhance the efficacy of this model by adding more variables such as players' performance statistics, weather conditions, and league rankings.

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How Cite this article?

Sona, S. R., & Iswarya, M. (2026). Cricket Meets Machine Learning: A Classification Approach to IPL Match Prediction. *RESEARCH HUB International Multidisciplinary Research Journal*, 13(4), 42-49. <https://doi.org/10.53573/rhimrj.2026.v13n04.006>